

# MAGIC AND EARLY SCIENCE

natural and occult philosophy

In the melting pot of Renaissance Europe, early distinctions between superstition, pseudoscience, and science were explored and formed. Natural philosophy (the study of the natural world) and occult philosophy (the study of powers said to be hidden in nature) were important in this process.

In the medieval period, the bishop William of Auvergne had defined natural magic as magic that made use of powers inherent in the natural world. The occult philosophy of the Renaissance was a companion and, in some ways, a successor to the study of natural magic. At this time there were overlaps between magic, philosophy, science, and religion, and some natural philosophers also sought to reveal the hidden natural causes of phenomena that appeared to be miraculous or supernatural.

## ▼ Between the lines

This engraving from Agrippa's *De occulta philosophia libri tres*, an important work of occult philosophy, shows lines and areas on the hand associated with zodiac symbols. Such guides were a cornerstone of Renaissance palmistry (also called chiromancy, or palm reading).

## Magic and natural philosophy

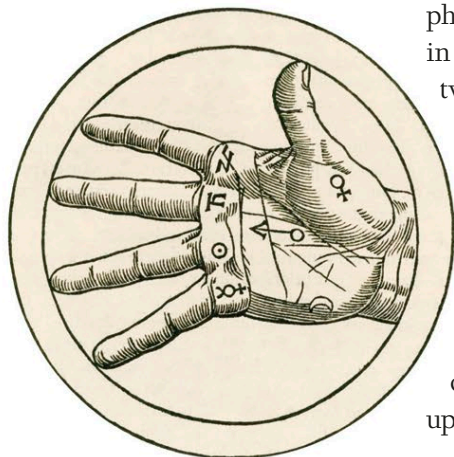
Natural philosophers studied the universal forces involved in aspects of astronomy, alchemy, and living things. They examined objects such as the sun, moon, plants, and rocks in terms of their physical properties, trying to identify and explain these by establishing general laws of nature. As Italian philosopher Pico della Mirandola (see p.137) said in his *Oratio de hominis dignitate* (1486): "... magic has two forms. One consists wholly in the operations and powers of demons ... The other proves ... to be nothing else but the highest realization of natural philosophy."

## The occult as a force for good

The magic studied by occult philosophers, seen as "good" and relatively scholarly, was contrasted with ceremonial magic, which called up spirits via rituals of theurgy, and goetia (see



p.143). Both science and magic were infused with Christian ideas. For example, alchemists saw parallels with the Resurrection in their mystical transmutation of metal into gold. The Church was largely unconcerned with areas such as astrology, but mixing religion with other disciplines required a fine balance and risked accusations of heresy. Yet, like followers of both Christianity and Hermeticism (see pp.134–135), occult philosophers sought the underlying principles of a divine natural order.



“As in Magic Natural, so in Divine.”

AGRIPPA, *DE OCCULTA PHILOSOPHIA LIBRI TRES*, 1530s